

Phascolarctos cinereus

Koala



Location E. Australia

Length 26–32 in
(65–82 cm)Tail $\frac{3}{4}$ – $\frac{3}{4}$ in
(1–2 cm)Weight $8\frac{3}{4}$ –33 lb
(4–15 kg)

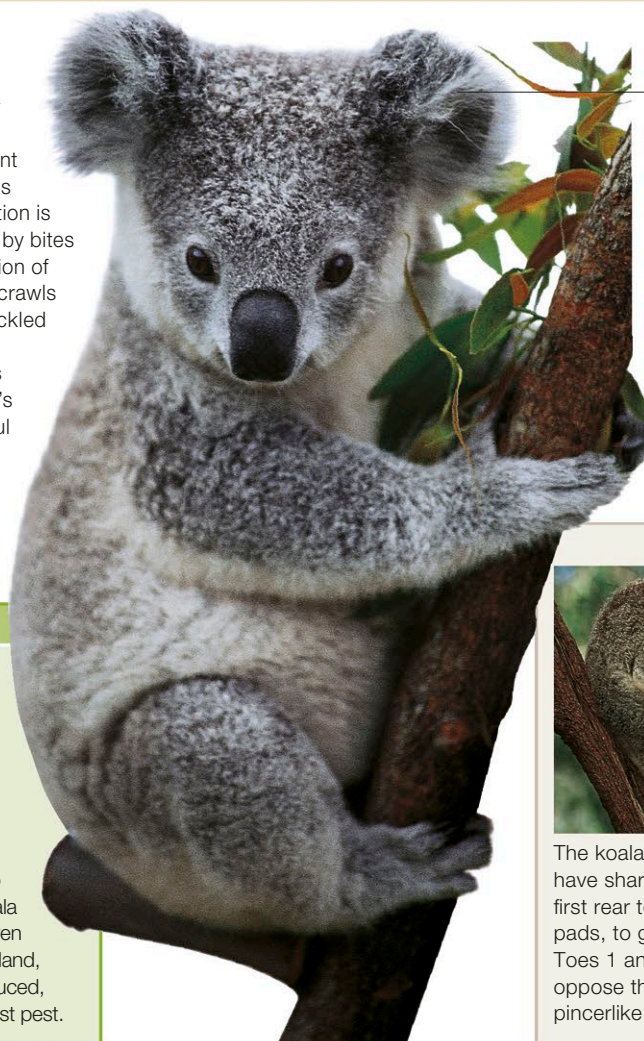
Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



The koala lives nearly all its life in eucalyptus trees. It feeds for about 4 hours at night, eating some 1 lb (500g) of leaves, and dozes for the remaining time, wedged securely in a branch fork. Occasionally, it descends

to change trees or promote digestion by eating soil, bark, and gravel. Individuals bellow to each other during the breeding season and dominant males mate with more females than do junior males. Copulation is brief and often accompanied by bites and scratches. After a gestation of 35 days, the single offspring crawls into the pouch, where it is suckled for 6 months. It then clings to the mother's back. Among its early solid food is the mother's droppings, which carry helpful food-digesting and disease-fighting microbes. Despite a placid appearance, the koala readily bites and scratches.

large, rounded,
white-tufted ears

BEARLIKE MARSUPIAL

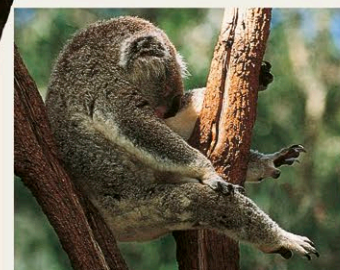
The koala's face is large and wide, like that of a bear, with a smooth black muzzle; the body is compact and thick set. The fur is soft, long, and mainly gray to gray-brown, with slightly paler underparts, and mottling on the rump.

CONSERVATION



Once common in Australia's eastern forests, the koala is in decline in some regions, mainly as a result of forest fragmentation, parasitic disease, and traffic accidents. Veterinary aid (see left) can be vital in saving lives. However, conservation measures have to be carried out with care, as koala populations can rise steeply given sufficient food. On Kangaroo Island, where koalas have been introduced, the species is now a major forest pest.

HOLDING ON



The koala's short, powerful limbs have sharp claws (except on the first rear toe) and granular paw pads, to grip bark and branches. Toes 1 and 2 on the front foot can oppose the other 3, allowing a pincerlike grasp of thin boughs.

Vombatus ursinus

Common wombat

Location E. Australia,
TasmaniaLength 28–47 in
(70–120 cm)Tail $\frac{3}{4}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$ in
(2–3 cm)Weight 55–88 lb
(25–40 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern

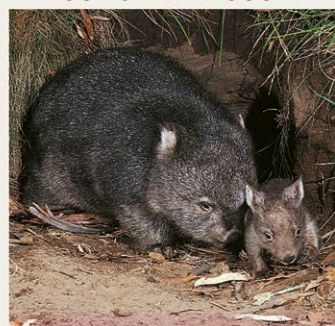


The common wombat has a hairless nose and remarkably bearlike form. A prolific burrower, its tunnel system generally has only one entrance but many underground branches, with a total length of up to 650 ft (200m). Preferred sites are slopes above creeks and valleys, where the wombat grazes, mainly at night, on grasses, sedges, roots, and tubers. In winter, it may

graze or sunbathe by day. Although wombats are generally solitary, and adult males tend to chase intruders from their home areas, they also seem to visit each other's burrows on occasion. After the offspring has left its mother's pouch, it stays at first in a nest chamber lined with dry grass and leaves, inside the burrow. The common wombat is not dangerous to humans, but its holes may trip horses, harbor dingoes, undermine banks, and damage rabbit-proof fences.

coarse, dense,
gray-tinged, brown fur

OUT OF THE POUCH



The common wombat usually produces a single offspring, which remains in the mother's pouch for about 10 months, although it may return there occasionally to suckle or seek shelter. Weaning occurs at about 15 months.

BROAD BURROWER

The common wombat's broad, angular head, compact body, and strong limbs with wide, large-clawed feet make it an accomplished digger.

Lasiorhinus latifrons

Southern hairy-nosed wombat



Location S. Australia

Length 30–37 in
(77–95 cm)Tail $1\frac{1}{4}$ – $2\frac{1}{4}$ in
(3–6 cm)Weight 42–71 lb
(19–32 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



Even stockier and shorter-limbed than the common wombat (see left), this species has longer ears, long, silky fur mottled brown and gray, and gray-white hairs on the snout. It is colonial, groups of 5–10 occupying a burrow system (warren) covering several hundred square yards. This wombat grazes at night on grass and other low vegetation. Senior males repel strangers of their kind unless these are receptive females at breeding time.

